

ATTACK ON AMERICA

As the North Tower of the World Trade Center burned after being hit by a hijacked plane, a second airliner headed straight for the South Tower.



Moments later, flames and smoke shot from the South Tower after it was struck by the second hijacked plane. *Kelly Guenther / New York Times photos*



NATION IN ANGUISH

Thousands feared dead after terrorists crash hijacked jets into World Trade Center, Pentagon



Firefighters gathered near what was the base of the World Trade Center yesterday just hours after the two towers collapsed. *Justin Lane / The New York Times*

Establishing final toll may be weeks off

ASSOCIATED PRESS

NEW YORK — In the aftermath of the most devastating terrorist onslaught ever waged against the United States, officials last night were assessing the wreckage and human toll while investigators began tracking down leads to determine who was responsible.

The nation was jolted yesterday morning when knife-wielding hijackers crashed two airliners into the World Trade Center, collapsing its twin 110-story towers. The calamity was witnessed on televisions throughout the world as a third plane slammed into the Pentagon, and a fourth crashed outside Pittsburgh.

Establishing the death toll could take weeks, but President Bush said thousands had perished. The four airliners alone had 266 people aboard and there were no known survivors. At the Pentagon, at least 100 people were believed dead, but

officials warned the toll could reach 800.

New York officials said there were an unconfirmed 265 firefighters and 85 police officers missing and feared dead near the trade center, where 50,000 people worked.

"The number of casualties will be more than most of us can bear," a distraught Mayor Rudolph Giuliani said.

Police sources said some people trapped in the towers managed to call authorities or family members and that some trapped police officers made radio contact. In one of the calls, which took place in the afternoon, a businessman phoned his family to say he was trapped with police officers, the source said.

Giuliani said two Port Authority police officers had been pulled from the ruins, and he said hope existed that more people could be saved.

SEE **Terrorism, A16**

"We will make no distinction between the terrorists who committed these acts and those who harbor them."

PRESIDENT BUSH

Bush vows U.S. will punish those behind 'these evil acts'

By **Finlay Lewis**
COPLEY NEWS SERVICE

WASHINGTON — President Bush vowed last night to avenge the terrorist attacks that killed thousands of Americans and forced the country to endure perhaps its most horrific day.

Speaking in deliberate and determined tones from the Oval Office after his own extraordinary daylong flight to elude danger, Bush sought to rally the country in the wake of a bloody day like no other.

"Terrorist attacks can shake

foundations of our biggest buildings, but they cannot touch the foundation of America," Bush said during a five-minute televised address. "These acts shatter steel, but they can't dent the steel of American resolve."

Bush served notice that America's response would be unsparing, even while attempting to help the nation come to terms with the grief arising from the airborne attacks on New York's World Trade Center and the Pentagon.

SEE **Bush, A2**

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Likely suspect

As investigators began the daunting task of finding who is to blame for the attacks, suspicion swiftly fell on one man: Osama bin Laden. **See A5**

Felled by fire

Heat from burning aviation fuel may have melted the steel girders supporting the World Trade Center's towers, causing them to collapse. **See A7**

Final call

A passenger on one of the doomed jetliners spent her last moments on a cell phone talking to her husband, the U.S. solicitor general. **See A13**

Local effects

The tragedy on the East Coast led to the evacuation of much of downtown San Diego while stranding thousands at the county's airports. **See A12**

Lasting damage

Yesterday's terrorist attacks could push the nation into the recession it has so far narrowly avoided, economists say. **See A15**

Delayed games

Major League Baseball called off last night's games because of the tragedy, and today's games are likely to be postponed, too. **Sports, D1**